

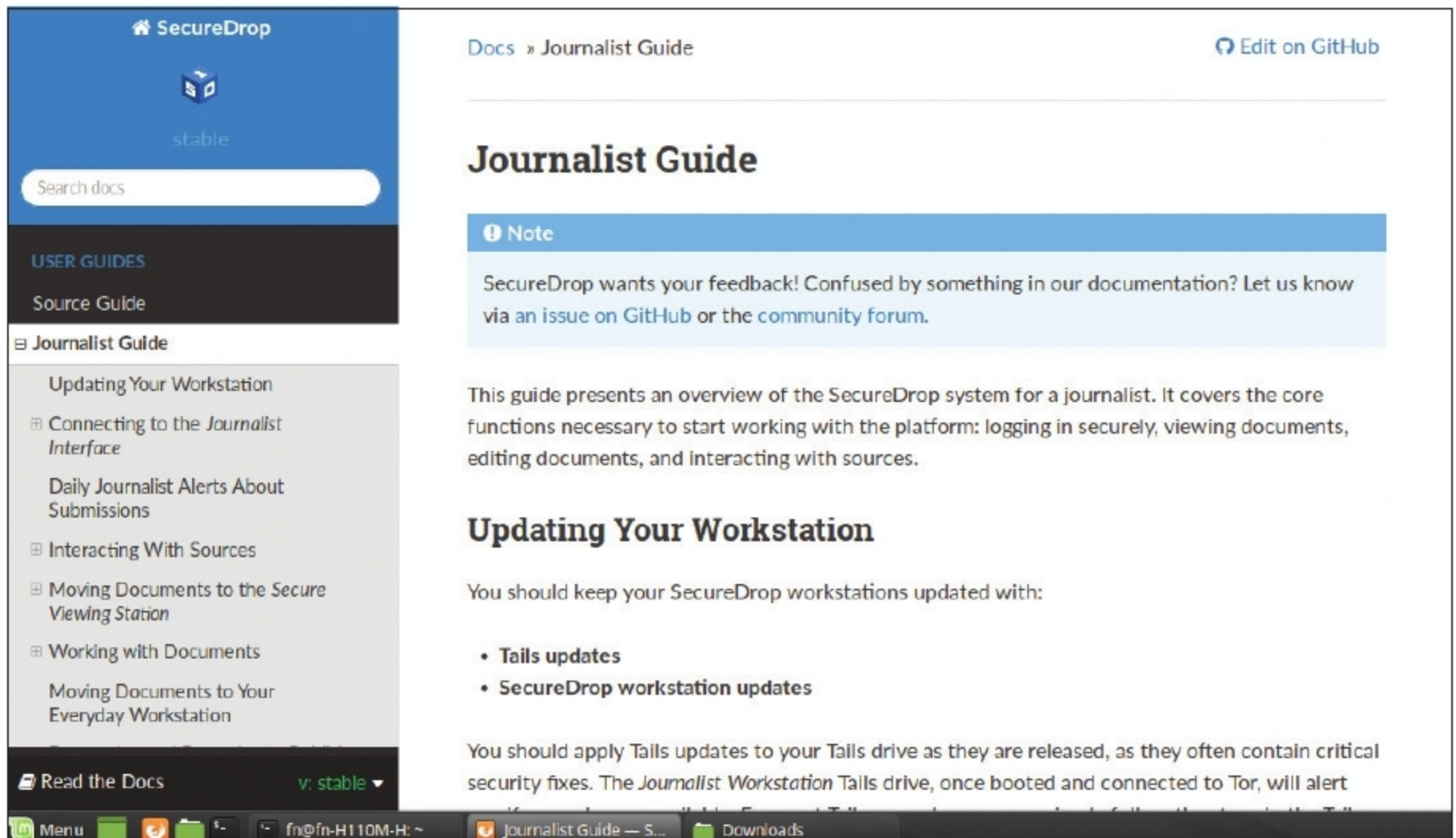


Figure 3: SecureDrop Journo

return there.” So there’s a lot of work involved for the whistleblower. But safety comes at a price.

At a single go, the software allows you to submit up to 500MB of data. It is localised, and can run on many different languages.

“It doesn’t have any JavaScript, which is one of the big evils, in every possible way. JavaScript can do many fancy things, but it can also blow away all your privacy and security,” adds Das.

Journalists have a different app running, in the same server. You have to log in with your passphrase and your OTP (one time password). Every source will get randomised names. Even the randomised ‘source’s’ name will not be revealed to the journalist.

Sources need to know which journalists to send their drops to, and how. Even the computer you use can be critical. If you plan to blow the whistle on a big scam involving powerful organisations, you need to take some precautions. Walk into a store with cash, buy the hardware, and get out. There will be instructions on how to open up

the hardware, and avoid any unauthorised access to the box.

SecureDrop can be accessed from a special room within the news organisation’s premises, and journalists use dedicated laptops in these rooms. The advice is to never carry any other electronic device with you when you go to access your journalist workstation. Also, you’re not supposed to take the laptop out of the secured locked room. After downloading a file onto one computer, save it on a USB drive or a write-only CD/DVD drive. Then place it onto a second computer, which can decrypt and show the original messages or files from the source.

Nowadays, even looking at the dots and full stops of a PDF document can tell investigators who leaked it, Das warns.

Das believes that all engineering students should learn about ethics. “It took me time to realise why ethics is so important for us,” he says.

He also feels that the issue of using and misusing the Net is sometimes misunderstood or exaggerated, in particular with regard to the Tor Project. Das points to some newspapers that have continually written about the ‘dark net’, creating all kinds of paranoia about it. When asked to write about the other side of the story, informing the public that Tor helps people with security and privacy, the press folk simply say, “That doesn’t sell,” Das complains.

So that’s a lot of work to be able to ensure the truth gets told. But history tells us, it’s worth it. **END** 🐧

References

- [1] The Story of Aaron Swartz - <http://bit.ly/AaronSwartzDocumentary>
- [2] Linux Users’ Group of Durgapur - <http://dgplug.org/archive/>
- [3] More about SecureDrop - <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/SecureDrop>

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